

IK 521: Connecting Indian Music with Life

Course Code	IK 521
Course Name	Connecting Indian Music with Life
L-T-P-C	2-1-2-4
Prerequisites	None
Intended for	M.A/ B. Tech/MTech/MS/MSc/PhD
Mutual Exclusion	There are no equivalent or overlapping courses across schools.
Approval	64th BoA (May 2026)

Preamble

This course explores the inherent connections between Indian music, nature, life and values, in an attempt to bridge Indian musical knowledge systems (passed on through Guru-Shishya Parampara) with contemporary understandings of emotion, cognition, wellbeing, creativity and holistic human lived experience. Through a balance of theory, tutorials and intensive experiential practice, students are expected to see Indian music not merely as a performance training, but as a transformative medium connecting sound, self, society and consciousness.

Course Modules

- **Module 1: Indian Music, Nature, Human Values and Life:**
 - Music as a way of life in Indian tradition – Connection to Indian Philosophies
 - *Guru-Shishya Paramparā* and holistic learning
 - Music, nature and the five elements
 - Human qualities and values in music learning: concentration, discipline, humility, acceptance, love, empathy, surrender
 - Uniqueness of Indian music:
 - * monophonic and vocal orientation
 - * *meend* and continuity
 - * cyclicity
 - * improvisation
 - * intuition
 - Music as self-discovery and inner development
- **Module 2: Sound & Breath, Long-Note Practice and Tānpurā:**
 - Acoustics and psychoacoustics of Indian music
 - Role of Sā and tonal reference
 - Tānpurā as the “Mother of Indian Music”
 - Difference between Indian natural shrutis and equally-tempered scale
 - Long-note practice with Aumkār and five different vowels: concentration, breath control, improving resonance, mindfulness
 - Importance of Dynamics modulation and its practice
 - Neurocognitive and therapeutic implications of drone and sustained tones
 - Music, respiration and attention regulation
- **Module 3: Sur Darshan and Tāl Darshan: Visualization, Embodiment and Creativity:**
 - Concept of Sur vs Swar
 - Visualization-oriented pedagogy
 - Synesthetic and embodied learning approaches
 - Sur Darshan: imagining melodic movement as painting on air with air
 - Tāl Darshan: visualizing laya, chhanda and tāl as painting on time
 - Kinaesthetic cognition in Indian rhythm
 - Conscious vs habitual practice
 - Role of improvisation in creativity development
 - Cognitive science of musical visualization
- **Module 4: Kāvya, Rāga and Emotional Communication through their Bonding:**

- Kāvya Darshan and lyrical visualization
- Bhāva and emotional communication
- Relationship between lyrics, melody and rhythm
- Lexical and non-lexical features of rāga
- *Meend, andolan, nyās, sparsha* and rāga personality
- Improvisation and emotional nuance
- Music, memory and affective processing
- **Module 5: Indian Music, Wellbeing and Contemporary Applications:**
 - Indian music and mindfulness
 - Music, cognition and emotional wellbeing
 - Music and mental health applications
 - Music for social harmony and world peace
 - Introduction to music-based therapeutic thinking
 - Contemporary interdisciplinary applications: learning & memory – education, emotional regulation and various other therapy, neuroscience, wellbeing, community engagement

Tutorial/Practical Components

- **Module 1:** Guided reflective listening sessions, Group discussions on music-life experiences, Voice-body awareness exercises, Introduction to mindful listening with tānpurā drone, Observation journal/Reflective Diary: “Music and Everyday Emotional Experience”, Comparative listening analysis: Hindustani, Carnatic, Various Indian devotional and folk and selected world traditions; Group presentation on Music, nature and life. Take home assignments on exploring these connectivities.
- **Module 2:** Daily long-note practice, Aumkār and vowel resonance exercises, Sound and Breath control with beats, Tānpurā playing and tuning demonstrations, Loudness modulation exercises, Voice projection and stability training, Recording and self-analysis of sustained-note practice. Take home assignments on sound, breath and mind connections.
- **Module 3:** Melodic visualization exercises, Simple one-way pattern and reverse-pattern pāltā practice, Beat visualization with hand gestures, multi-sensory rhythm exercises, Metronome-based tempo awareness, Group improvisation exercises, Rhythmic movement and mind-body coordination, Creation of visual melodic maps. Take home assignments on sur & tāl darshan.
- **Module 4:** Lyric interpretation exercises (Reading lyrics without & with melody) with songs of different genres – classical, devotional, folk, singing with emotional modulation, Comparative rāga mood analysis, Bandish learning with expressive phrasing, Improvisation maintaining rāga bhāva, Group discussions on emotional perception in music, Emotion-analysis presentation, Analysis of general vs. reflective performance. Take home assignments on rāga bhava and kāvya bhava connectivity.
- **Module 5:** Designing music-based wellbeing exercises (in the form of mini research/project), Community or classroom-based demonstrations, Guided relaxation using rāga and Tānpurā drone, Applied music intervention models, Final integrative practical presentation. Take home assignments like experiment designing, data collection and analysis and mini-project presentations.

Text Books

- a. *Shrutinandan* by Ajoy Chakrabarty, Macmillan Publishers India Ltd., 2002.
- b. *Finding the Raga: An Improvisation on Indian Music* by Amit Chaudhuri, Penguin Hamish Hamilton Publishers, 2021.

References

- a. Saarikallio, S., Alluri, V., Maksimainen, J., & Toiviainen, P. (2021). Emotions of music listening in Finland and in India: Comparison of an individualistic and a collectivistic culture. *Psychology of Music*, 49(4), 989-1005.
- b. Valla, J. M., Alappatt, J. A., Mathur, A., & Singh, N. C. (2017). Music and emotion—a case for north indian classical music. *Frontiers in psychology*, 8, 2115.
- c. *Natyasastra of Bharatmuni* (Vol. 1,2,3,4) Sanskrit Text with Abhinavabharati commentary (Sanskrit Edition), Editor R. S. Nagar, Parimal Publications Delhi, 2012.
- d. *Hindustani Sangeet Paddhati Kramik Pustak Malika* (Part 1 to 6) by Pandit Vishnu Narayan Bhatkhande and Harishchandra Shrivastava, Sangeet Sadan Prakashan, 2022
- e. *Music Revisited: The Shrutinandan Way* by Ajoy Chakrabarty, (with publishers)